
A FIELD GUIDE

Data Quality & Deduplication

Keep Your CRM Clean, Accurate & Trustworthy

Six precision lessons on spotting, preventing, and fixing the data problems that silently corrupt your HubSpot portal.

Six Lessons to Stop Bad Data Before It Spreads

1

Duplicate Contact Detection

Find and merge dupes before they split history and inflate counts.

2

Property Value Pollution

Why free-text fields destroy segmentation — and how to fix them.

3

Original Source Protection

How imports silently overwrite first-touch attribution.

4

Mandatory Field Gaps

Required fields don't stop APIs or imports — here's the real fix.

5

Stale Contact Downgrade

Cut your database bill by demoting ghosts, not deleting them.

6

Import Mode Mismatch

The silent overwrite trap hiding inside 'Create and update' mode.

Duplicate Contact Detection

THE PROBLEM

- Duplicate contacts split engagement history across two records, causing workflows to fire twice and MQL counts to inflate artificially.
- Spot it: Settings → Data Management → Duplicate Management shows unresolved pairs; a list filtered by 'Duplicate of contact ID is known' surfaces them in bulk.
- Without merging, doubled email addresses cause ISPs to count your sends twice, skewing deliverability metrics and open-rate benchmarks.

THE FIX

- HubSpot's native dedup tool matches on exact email and fuzzy name+company — review fuzzy matches manually before approving each merge.
- Merges are non-reversible: the 'winner' keeps its original create date and Original Source; the 'loser' record's timeline events are absorbed but its property values are not.
- For integrations, pre-check with GET `/crm/v3/objects/contacts?email=` before any write to prevent net-new duplicates from entering the portal.

TAKEAWAY

Trust email-match duplicates; audit every fuzzy-name merge one by one before committing.

Property Value Pollution

THE PROBLEM

- Free-text properties like 'Company Name' accumulate spelling variants ('HubSpot', 'hubspot', 'HubSpot Inc.') that silently break list filters and report groupings.
- Spot it: build a Contacts report grouped by the suspect property — if one logical value has 10+ distinct spellings, the field is polluted.
- Downstream impact: any workflow or list using that property as a trigger misses records with variant spellings, creating invisible segmentation gaps.

THE FIX

- Switch fields used in segmentation, scoring, or reporting to dropdown or radio select property types; picklist enforcement blocks new bad values via forms.
- Migrate existing data with a workflow: enroll contacts where the old free-text property is known → use 'Set property value' to write to a new clean dropdown field.
- Note: picklist enforcement applies only to the UI and forms — direct API writes and imports bypass it, so also validate at the integration layer.

TAKEAWAY

Any property you filter, score, or report on must be a picklist — never a free-text field.

Original Source Protection

THE PROBLEM

- The 'Original Source' property is meant to be immutable, set at contact creation — but imports and some integrations silently overwrite it.
- Spot it: check your Contacts source breakdown report after any bulk import — an unexpected spike in 'Offline Sources' is the tell.
- Corrupted original source breaks top-of-funnel attribution for every affected contact, making channel ROI reporting unreliable retroactively.

THE FIX

- During any import, leave 'Original Source' and both 'Drill-down' columns unmapped — HubSpot locks them at creation-time, preserving existing values.
- For net-new CSV imports, HubSpot sets Original Source to 'Offline Sources'; add a custom 'Import Batch ID' property to track provenance instead.
- Use 'Latest Source' (hs_analytics_last_source) for most-recent-touch analysis; use Original Source only for true first-touch cohort queries.

TAKEAWAY

Never map an import column to Original Source — it's a write-once field you protect by omission.

Mandatory Field Gaps

THE PROBLEM

- HubSpot 'Required Properties' (per-pipeline for deals, global for contacts) block manual UI saves — but have no effect on API writes, imports, or workflows.
- Spot it: a Deals report grouped by 'Deal Owner' with a large 'No value' bar means required-field enforcement is failing for programmatically created deals.
- Missing close dates break forecast roll-ups; missing owners mean no one follows up — both are silent revenue leaks that compound over time.

THE FIX

- Create a workflow: 'Deal is created' → 30-minute delay → branch if 'Close Date is unknown OR Deal Owner is unknown' → assign a remediation task to the portal admin.
- For Operations Hub Pro portals, use a custom-coded workflow action to enforce field presence and write a 'Data Quality Flag' property for audit reporting.
- Track progress monthly: a Deals report filtered by 'Create date in last 30 days' AND 'Close Date is unknown' — the count should trend to zero.

TAKEAWAY

Required fields are a UI guardrail only — pair them with a post-create workflow that catches every other entry vector.

Stale Contact Downgrade

THE PROBLEM

- HubSpot bills by Marketing Contact count regardless of engagement; contacts untouched for 18+ months inflate your bill with zero pipeline contribution.
- Spot it: a Contacts report filtered by 'Last Activity Date before 550 days ago' AND 'Marketing Contact Status = Marketing' — anything over 5% is a concern.
- Stale contacts tank deliverability: low engagement signals trigger ISP spam filters, hurting inbox placement for your active list too.

THE FIX

- Build a re-engagement workflow on 'Last Activity Date > 550 days ago AND Email Subscribed = true' → send one 'Still interested?' email, then wait 14 days.
- Branch on click or open: with no engagement, set Marketing Contact Status to Non-marketing (removes billing) and unsubscribe from all email.
- Downgrading beats deleting — contact history, deals, and timeline events are preserved for reporting, and the contact can be re-subscribed if they re-engage.

TAKEAWAY

Demote ghost contacts to non-marketing rather than deleting them — save the history, cut the bill.

Import Mode Mismatch

THE PROBLEM

- HubSpot's 'Create and update' import mode silently overwrites existing property values on any record whose email matches a row in your file, including lifecycle stage.
- If your file has a 'Lifecycle Stage' column set to 'Lead', every matched contact gets downgraded to Lead, regardless of their current stage.
- Spot it: check the import activity log (Contacts → Actions → Import) — a high 'Updated' count relative to 'Created' signals unintended overwrites.

THE FIX

- Use 'Create only' mode for net-new record files; use a separate import with only the delta columns for intentional updates — never mix both in one file.
- Remove any column you do NOT want to update from the file before uploading: HubSpot writes to every mapped column, so the narrowest file is the safest.
- After any import, run a Contacts report filtered by 'Last Modified Date = today' and manually spot-check 3-5 records for unexpected changes.

TAKEAWAY

One import file, one purpose: use 'Create only' for new records and a separate file for intentional updates.

PRINCIPLES

Four Rules for a Clean HubSpot Portal

- 1** Picklists over free text: any field used in filters, scoring, or reports must have controlled values.
- 2** Validate at every entry vector: UI required fields, API guards, and post-create workflows are all three necessary layers.
- 3** Protect first-touch attribution: Original Source is write-once — omit it from every import, forever.
- 4** Downgrade before you delete: non-marketing status cuts billing while preserving history for future reporting.